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LOSING A FLAVOR OF PILSEN

La Casa del Pueblo Taqueria, forced out after 60 years, fights for one last Christmas in Chicago neighborhood

By Laura Rodríguez Presa | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The essence of the Mexican immigrants who shaped Pilsen into the neighborhood it is today are found in its murals, the flavors that inspire new restaurants and in the people who have carried its culture forward. But as time marches on, fewer of those pioneering immigrants — and the places they built — remain.

La Casa del Pueblo Taqueria has remained a living link to the immigrants who began arriving in Pilsen decades ago. Some of those early patrons still return religiously to the restaurant, a place that makes them feel at home.

Now, the taqueria, which has held on to its homemade flavors for the past 60 years, will soon disappear, too.

When Alberto Gonzalez walked into the restaurant at 1834 S. Blue Island Ave. on a recent morning, Martha Saucedo, 84, rushed to greet him. He and his wife have been going to the restaurant since the 1960's, when they first arrived from Mexico.

"I heard you're closing. Why?! What are we going to do without you?" Gonzalez asked Saucedo. "I hope you guys don't leave."

But it's inevitable. Earlier this year, Nicholas Lombardi Jr., the owner of the building that houses the restaurant, asked Saucedo and her family to leave the premises. In early September, Lombardi Jr. filed an eviction lawsuit against the family, alleging that the "occupants refused to surrender possession of the property within the time specified."

The request to vacate the building came as a surprise to Saucedo, who has known the Lombardi family since she and her mother first started serving homemade soup and other dishes from the back corner of his grandfather's supermarket in the 1960s.

That supermarket is La Casa del Pueblo Supermarket, located next door to the restaurant on Blue Island Avenue. It is now owned by Lombardi Jr. and is not affiliated with the taqueria. On paper, at least.

His grandfather, Jerri Lombardi, and father, Nicholas Lombardi, were the original owners of the building and supermarket. They offered to rent the restaurant's current space to Saucedo and her mother based solely on a handshake agreement in 1992,

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Manager Jorge Arturo Haro Hernandez greets longtime customer Lupe Gonzalez at La Casa del Pueblo Taqueria in Chicago's Pilsen neighborhood on Sept. 17. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Envisioning possibilities

Statewide U. of I. tour helps system deepen connections with its potential students

By Kate Perez
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Lindblom Math and Science Academy students sat in a semicircle with some of the University of Illinois System's top officials, notebooks in front of them and pens in hand. The goal: a discussion in which the university establishment listened as prospective pupils asked questions and shared their ideas for improving the path to higher education.

Englewood-based Lindblom served as the launch of the University of Illinois System's annual tour Tuesday, giving students, parents and school faculty members face time with leadership from all three campuses — including Tim Killeen, who helms the U. of I. system.

This marks the sixth year of the "Invested in Illinois State Tour," which aims to help leadership at all three of the system's campuses — Urbana-Champaign, Chicago and Springfield — deepen connections to stakeholders by traveling around the state to businesses, community colleges, high schools and other locations, to listen to



Lindblom Math and Science Academy student Alexia Banks talks to officials from the University of Illinois on Tuesday in Chicago about preparing for college and career choices. **TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

people's needs and priorities when it comes to the college application process and higher education accessibility.

Inside Lindblom, university leaders playfully lobbied on behalf of their campuses to a group of more than a dozen participants, who fired inquiries back about courses, postgraduation job success rates, campus accessibility and culture, and more.

While questions spanned from campus disability services to how racism is handled, concerns were met with reassurance from university officials with promises of advis-

ers, academic support programming and mental health resources.

Lindblom senior Alexia Banks asked leadership at the meeting how those on campus balance academic work and social life. The meeting helped make the university's processes feel more transparent, Banks said, making the decision of choosing where to apply to and attend college a bit easier.

"Having people who really know the school be able to answer these questions,

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SUPREME COURT

Data set OK'd to screen voters

States can resume using controversial federal tool to cross-check eligibility

By Ali Swenson, John Hanna and Lindsay Whitehurst
ASSOCIATED PRESS

NEW YORK — The Supreme Court on Friday lifted restrictions on a controversial federal voter database before November's elections, granting President Donald Trump a temporary win in his aggressive campaign against noncitizen voting.

The court's three liberal-leaning justices publicly dissented from the decision.

The emergency order allows states, for now, to use the Trump administration's revamped version of a Department of Homeland Security program, called Systematic Alien Verification for Entitlements, or SAVE, in their efforts to verify the eligibility of voters on their rolls. It's a program that has drawn scrutiny for its use of voters' sensitive personal data and its tendency to wrongly flag some eligible voters as noncitizens.

States' use of the SAVE program is voluntary, limiting the ruling's impact on the midterm elections. Existing law also blocks most states from systematically purging voters from their rolls within 90 days of an election, said David Becker, an election law expert who leads the Center for Election Innovation and Research. He said DHS itself has admitted the data is not perfect.

Maine Secretary of State Shenna Bellows, a Democrat who refuses to participate in the SAVE program, said the ruling will have no effect in her state because it "does not force states to change the way we run our elections."

The plaintiffs and their lawyers in the case called the ruling "profoundly disappointing" and said it puts "millions of Americans at risk of being unlawfully targeted by the administration's unreliable voter purge database" before the midterms.

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Pace unveils little libraries for 'Dolly Day'

By Shun Graves
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A bus driver walked up and peered at the little wooden box on a metal post that had just appeared Friday at the Northwest Transportation Center in Schaumburg.

The box had a small door with a window, and above that, a pink placard read "In memory of Dolly Parton." Inside were children's books, a dictionary of medical abbreviations and various other volumes.

As the signs on the buses parked nearby spelled out, it was "Dolly Day," so named because of the date being Sept. 25, or 9/25, in a nod to Parton's movie "9 to 5" and its eponymous hit song.

Pace amped up the celebration by unveiling the little libraries at transfer points across Chicagoland. It was a public-transit twist on communities across the country celebrating Parton, the country superstar who died in August.

"I gave a call over to my marketing crew, and I said, 'hey, it's '9/25,' after the Dolly Parton movie," Pace Executive Director Melinda Metzger said. "Let's do something fun."

The brainstorming began with the destination signs on the buses. Soon the

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